Project: StoryCast, an accessible media microsite

1. Project summary

StoryCast is a three-page microsite that presents short audio and video stories. It is built with semantic HTML5, Sass, CSS Grid, Flexbox, and a container query, with no frameworks. Its main goal is that every story can be experienced in more than one way, so no visitor is left out because of how they see, hear, or navigate the web.

2. Audience and needs

StoryCast is designed for a general audience, with particular attention to people who:

- are deaf or hard of hearing and need captions and transcripts
- are blind or have low vision and use screen readers or zoom
- cannot use a mouse and rely on the keyboard
- are in a place where they cannot play sound, or prefer to read

Each group is served by a specific feature: captions and transcripts for the first, landmarks and a clean heading order for the second, a skip link and visible focus for the third, and written transcripts for the fourth.

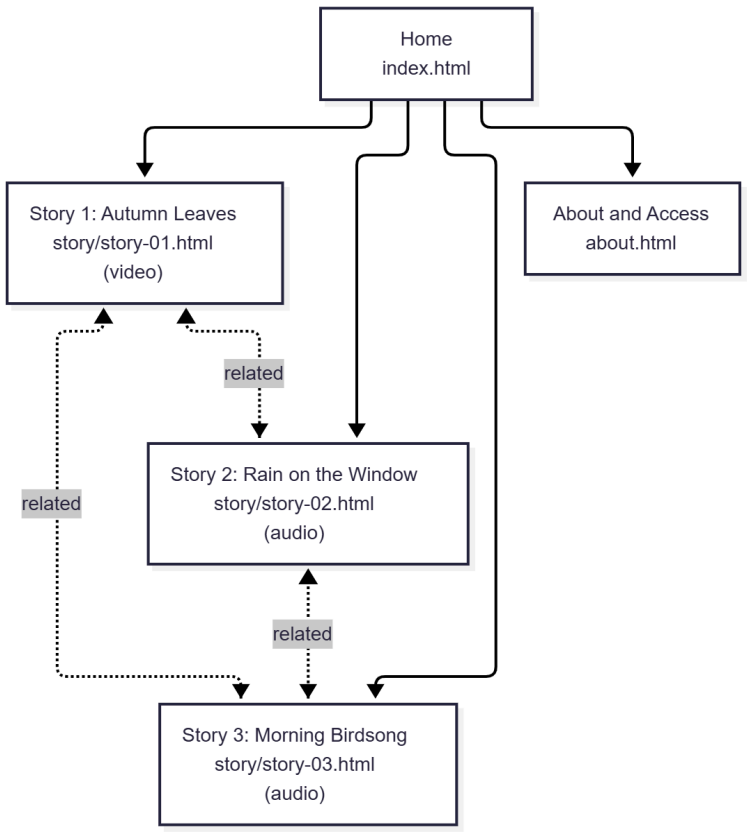
3. Information architecture

The site has three page types:

- **Home** (index.html): introduces StoryCast and links to the featured stories and the About page.
- **Story** (story/story-01.html, story-02.html, story-03.html): one story per page, with the player, a description, a transcript, and related stories. Story 1 is a video (Autumn Leaves), and stories 2 and 3 are audio (Rain on the Window, Morning Birdsong).
- **About and Access** (about.html): the mission, the accessibility features, and how to explore the site.

The sitemap (docs/sitemap.png) shows the structure. Home is the hub: it links to all three stories and to About. The stories link to each other through a "Related stories" section, so a visitor can keep going without returning home. The main navigation (Home, Stories, About and Access) appears on every page in the same place, so the way around the site is always predictable.

Content hierarchy on each page follows the same order: header and navigation, page heading, main content, related content, footer. Headings follow a strict order of one h1 per page, h2 for sections, and h3 for cards and feature items.



4. Design decisions

- **Layout:** the wireframes fixed the order and grouping of content before any code was written. The high-fidelity mockups added color, type, and real text, and the built site follows them.
- **Color:** a deep purple for the header, buttons, and links; a pale lavender for the hero and transcript areas; a near-black for text and the footer. Colors were chosen to meet WCAG 2.1 AA contrast and were checked with Chrome Lighthouse.
- **Typography:** a serif face for headings, and the system sans-serif for body text at 18px for comfortable reading.
- **Responsive behavior:** grids use auto-fit columns, so card rows reflow from three columns to one without relying only on media queries. The media card is a container query component: its title and text grow when the card is wider than 24rem, regardless of window width.

5. Accessibility approach

Requirement	How StoryCast meets it
Text alternatives for media	Video has English captions through a track element (story-01.vtt); every audio and video story has a full transcript on the page, including important sounds
Structure and landmarks	header, nav, main, article, section, figure, and footer on every page; one h1 per page and a logical heading order
Keyboard use	All content is reachable by keyboard; a skip link is the first focusable item on

	every page
Visible focus	A 3px outline on all interactive elements, purple on light backgrounds and yellow on dark ones
Orientation	The current page is marked in the navigation with aria-current and is not shown by color alone (bold plus an underline)
ARIA	Labels on navigation regions, aria-labelledby on sections, and aria-current for the current page, used only where HTML alone is not enough
Contrast and zoom	Colors chosen for AA contrast; layout checked at 200 percent zoom and on a narrow mobile width
Motion	Animations and transitions are turned off for users who prefer reduced motion

6. Technical approach

- Sass partials hold design tokens (_colors, _typography, _spacing), and each token is also exposed as a CSS custom property.
- CSS cascade layers (reset, base, layout, components, utilities) are declared once in _layers.scss, so the order of styles does not depend on specificity.
- Class names follow BEM (for example media-card__title and nav__link).
- The project uses no frameworks, only HTML, Sass compiled to CSS, and no JavaScript.

7. Testing

Each page was checked with Chrome Lighthouse (Accessibility), by navigating with the keyboard only, at 200 percent zoom, and at a narrow phone width in the browser's device tools. Issues found were fixed before submission.

8. Media credits

- Autumn Leaves: video by Kris Møklebust from Pexels
- Rain on the Window: audio by PWLPL from Pixabay
- Morning Birdsong: audio by Creative_Spark from Pixabay

9. Links

- GitHub repository: https://github.com/Melyssa-Ingabe/storycast
- Figma (wireframes and mockups): https://www.figma.com/design/j32T6KzJ4OqOhpegSQVavo/StoryCast?node-id=1-142&t=IploMlBXFu9iEKcl-1